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FireDistinguishers



Congress 100: House Leadership and What They're Leading

Effortpost

Introduction

A few months ago [I wrote an effortpost explaining the ins and outs of the Federal Budget process](#). I thought people had absolutely no idea how the Budget was enacted back *then*, so you can only imagine how it feels to watch people on twitter and instagram give their ignorant takes on the process now that it's under the news-cycle spotlight. Now, we're a just a handful of days away from the 117th Congress being sworn-in, and I can't WAIT to hear more stupid opinions.

But come on, we know better than to talk about things we don't understand, so let's dive a little deeper into the shallow end of the pool and learn about what's REALLY going on in the Capitol Building, starting with the basics, then getting into the fun stuff.

What Congress is it?

We're currently living during the tail end of the 116th Congress of the United States. In January, the 117th Congress will be sworn in, and it'll last for two one-year sessions until in January 2023 when the 118th Congress begins. These numbers are the reason you might see a law described as: PL 116-136 (that's the CARES Act by the way). PL means Public Law, and then you know that this particular law was the 136th law that the 116th Congress passed.

Majoritarianism and You

The House is partisan and majoritarian (please, please, save your applause for the end). In the House, all you need is 50% + 1 vote for anything to get done, so basically everything that goes on in the House is dictated by the rules and agendas of the majority party (in a way you might not really appreciate until you understand how different that is from operations in the Senate).

One reason the House is so majoritarian is that over there the party in control publishes a pretty long document called *The Rules of the House of Representatives* by passing a resolution called "the Rules Package" on the first day of a new Congress.

The Rules Package turns out to be about 700 pages of somewhat useful information mixed with arcane bullshit that lays out every single change or new rule added to previous documents by previous Congresses all the way back to the days when Thomas Jefferson was alive.

"Oh I get it," you might be thinking "If I want to understand Congress I should read this thing."

Don't. Congressional staff don't read this thing, Members of Congress don't read this thing, seriously it's so long, nobody can read this thing.

The only people who *do* read this thing in full are the folks working in the Office of the House Parliamentarian, a group of people whose entire job is to help everyone else in the House understand exactly what rules they

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around, and with every successive Congress the advantage has only become *more* exaggerated. Nowadays the most junior majority party members rival the power of the House minority leadership. Am I stretching the truth a little here to get a laugh? Only a little bit, that's what's so messed up.

The Congressional Calendar, and the Congressional Work Week

At noon on January 3rd in the year after an election, a new Congress officially begins and everyone's officially on the clock. But what does the clock look like? Weirdly enough, it looks like a calendar.

The Congressional Calendar plans out each day, week, month, quarter, and term for the House. Since we're not living in the colonial period anymore and people can fly back to their districts, the typical Washington work week for Reps in the House is 4-5 days.

These work weeks start when the weekly session is "gaveled-in" sometime after noon on the first day of the week (which could either be Monday or Tuesday). At around 6:30 pm on that day there's something called a "bed-check vote," that's some noncontroversial item that makes sure the Reps found their way back to DC and into the Capitol in a reasonable amount of time, but it's also something that they won't need a major policy briefing for before casting their vote on it.

"But [u/firedistinguishers](#)," I hear you asking, "what if the Majority Leader mixes things up for those poor bastards and makes them vote for something complicated with national, or even global, implications even though they just spent an entire weekend running around their constituency and upwards of 8 hours on a long-haul flight?"

We'll talk about the Senate later.

As the work week goes on, more controversial and more impactful legislative work starts to get done, gradually of course. Day 2 might include some light work and maybe some partisan bills that need a vote, but by days 3, 4, and 5 the House is debating the REAL shit.

Chamber Leadership

Here are all the positions of people who can say they're part of House leadership:

The Speaker of the House; The House Majority Leader (and the Minority Leader); The House Majority Whip (and the Minority Whip); The House Democratic Caucus Chair; The House Republican Conference Chair, and; The Chair of the Rules Committee.

These assholes get to be who they are in different ways. The Speaker is elected by the whole chamber with a simple majority vote (remember how I called the House majoritarian?). The Rules Committee Chair is picked by the Speaker. The other bastards are elected from a pool of votes collected from members of the specific party they represent.

The Speaker of the House

Nancy Pelosi is the only officer of the House whose job is mentioned in the Constitution, all those other guys can move around and get swapped out but it'd take an amendment to get rid of the Speaker.

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Partisan? Yes. Contentious even within party lines? Yes. The cause of major delays in Congressional business? Technically yes, but not for like a century at this point, so kinda no.

As Speaker, Pelosi gets to pick the candidates for the House administrative officers: the Clerk (who's unique to the House, my checks come from the Senate Secretary), the Parliamentarian, the Sergeant-at-arms, the Chaplain, the Chief Accountability Officer, and so on.

Legislatively, the Speaker presides over the chamber, meaning if you're on the floor, then you have to ask Pelosi nicely to be allowed to talk, she can decide to let you or not let you (and how long you have to talk), and she can have the Sergeant-at-arms to come teach you some manners if you misbehave. She also rules on points of order, we'll talk about that in the next post.

When it comes to House Committees, nobody can match the Speaker's clout either. The Speaker straight up just picks the Chair of the Rules Committee at the start of each Congress, and she herself is the Chair of the Steering Committee (the Committee that picks all the other Committee Chairs, and that picks the lineup of Majority party Representatives on those Committees). In *theory*, all the members of the Steering Committee pick the Chairs of the other Committees, but that little factoid forgets that the Speaker of the House has more votes than anyone else on the Steering Committee so it'll take serious opposition to go in a different direction. The House is partisan and majoritarian.

And the Speaker's office approves travel requests for everybody in the House. I don't know if anybody's been a dick about that yet. Definitely can be though, but we'll talk about McConnell and his bullshit vacation-stealing later.

Those Other Guys in the Majority

The House Majority Leader's big job is being in charge of the Calendar. Steny Hoyer is in control of when legislation moves on and off the House floor, when and which bills are getting considered on a particular day, and the time when votes are taken, the time when the week starts, and the time when the week ends.

The House Majority Whip's job is to figure out how people are feeling about legislation. Jim Clyburn is Pelosi's people person. His whole job is to have a sense of which offices would or wouldn't cooperate if certain language was put in a certain bill, and maybe negotiate with some folks who aren't too happy to try and figure out how to sweeten the deal enough to secure cooperation. His office is also the group of official vote-counters / exit-pollsters on every bill that reaches a floor vote.

In the 116th and the 117th that's coming up, the Democrats are in the Majority, meaning the Democratic Caucus Chair is technically a part of Majority Leadership. Hakeem Jeffries' job is to, with the help of all the other leadership and with the help of individual party members, write up the House Democrats' platform. There are some positions within the Party Caucus who serve as party leadership but they aren't Chamber leadership, so I won't go into them and their jobs here.

The Guys in the Minority

The entire point of the minority leadership in the House is to complain about every decision the Majority makes and explain how they'd do things differently. There's an equivalent to everybody I mentioned up top,

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One weird thing, the Republicans call their equivalent to the "Democratic Caucus," the "Republican Conference." They also have more party leadership positions because they split the Vice-Chair and Secretary jobs, but only in the House for some reason. It's weird, don't worry about it.

Conclusion

The House is partisan and majoritarian (clap for that you stupid bastards). In a few days I'll write a post about House rules

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GilmanB • 6y ago

When it comes to House Committees, nobody can match the Speaker's clout either. The Speaker straight up just picks the Chair of the Rules Committee at the start of each Congress, and she herself is the Chair of the Steering Committee (the Committee that picks all the other Committee Chairs, and that picks the lineup of Majority party Representatives on those Committees). In theory, all the members of the Steering Committee pick the Chairs of the other Committees, but that little factoid forgets that the Speaker of the House has more votes than anyone else on the Steering Committee so it'll take serious opposition to go in a different direction. The House is partisan and majoritarian.

I'm not sure this is correct. Doesn't the full caucus vote for committee chairs/ranking members, at least on the Democratic side? The steering committee makes their recommendation, and although it's rare for the full caucus to go against that, it isn't unheard of. For instance, in 2014, Frank Pallone defeated Anne Eshoo to serve as the top Dem on Energy & Commerce, despite the fact that she had Pelosi's backing and won the steering committee vote.



FireDistinguishers **OP** • 6y ago

You're right, I was hoping to make that point in my next post about the House when I went over the Democratic caucus and the Republican conference a bit more. Unfortunately I hit the 10,000 character limit with this post a bit too quickly, so I had to trim it down a lot.



TrekkiMonstr • 2y ago

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r/agedlikemilk lol



AutoModerator MOD • 6y ago

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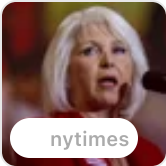
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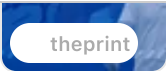
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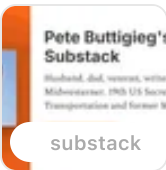
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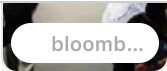
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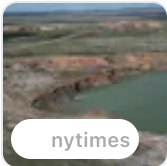
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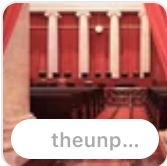
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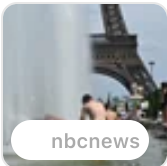
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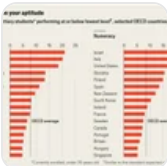
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